

RISK vs. REWARD – Full Pitch

Every choice is yours. Can you handle the pressure?

CONCEPT OVERVIEW

RISK vs. REWARD is a high-stakes trivia game show where contestants don't just answer questions—they decide exactly how much every question is worth.

In the standard one-hour format, two contestants each play a complete 12-question game, creating two distinct journeys toward the million-dollar prize. Each contestant chooses a category, examines a multiple-choice question and four possible answers, and then uses a dynamic Risk/Reward Slider to determine how much confidence to place in their answer.

As the slider moves, the game instantly updates the consequences of that decision—showing contestants what they stand to gain if they're right, what they stand to lose if they're wrong, and how the choice affects their path to the \$1,000,000 top prize.

Contestants see the question and all four answers before making a risk decision. They never have to gamble blindly.

A perfect game played at maximum risk earns \$1,000,000.

Every contestant must answer all 12 questions, making every decision part of a larger strategic journey.

Knowledge gets contestants into the game.

Confidence determines how far they go.

HOW THE GAME WORKS

Each contestant plays a complete game consisting of 12 rounds. Every round follows a simple structure.

1. Choose a Category

Contestants select one category from a board of available trivia topics.

The game features 13 categories, providing a continuing strategic dilemma: use a strong subject early to build momentum, or save it for later when the stakes may be dramatically higher?

The category selection comes first, before the contestant sees the question.

2. See the Question

A multiple-choice trivia question is revealed along with four possible answers.

Contestants have all the information they need before making a risk decision. They can study the question, consider the available answers, and evaluate how confident they feel.

The game never asks contestants to gamble blindly.

3. Set the Risk

Using the Risk/Reward Slider, contestants decide how much confidence to place in their answer.

The slider allows contestants to choose a position between minimum and maximum risk. As the slider moves, the display updates in real time, showing:

- Potential gain if correct.
- Potential loss if incorrect.
- Highest possible final total.
- Lowest possible final total.

The potential gain and loss change according to the slider's position. Contestants can see how every adjustment affects both the current question and the remaining possibilities in their game.

The minimum-risk setting limits exposure but also limits the potential reward. Maximum risk provides the opportunity for the largest gain while putting the contestant's current total at greater risk.

RISK vs. REWARD

Question: 1 Category: Landmarks

If you are facing the Mount Rushmore National Memorial, which President is shown on the far right side?

- ☐ A) Thomas Jefferson
- ☐ B) Theodore Roosevelt
- ☐ C) Abraham Lincoln
- ☐ D) George Washington

-\$272.47 RISK REWARD \$329.84

Countdown: 86

If you miss...

You now have:	\$533.67
Minus RISK:	\$272.47
You would have:	\$261.20
The Least You Can Win:	\$0.01
The Most You Can Win:	\$251,178.56

If you are correct...

You now have:	\$533.67
Plus REWARD:	\$329.84
You would have:	\$863.51
The Least You Can Win:	\$0.04
The Most You Can Win:	\$830,362.85

Lock in Answer

The contestant can adjust the slider while considering the question and answers, then decide how much confidence to put behind the answer.

4. Lock It In

Before time expires, contestants finalize both their answer and their Risk/Reward setting.

Once locked, neither can be changed.

A correct answer increases the contestant's total according to the selected risk level.

An incorrect answer reduces it according to that same decision.

Then the next round begins, with a new category selection, a new question, and another opportunity to weigh confidence against consequences.

Every answer matters. Every decision changes what's possible next.

THE PATH TO A MILLION

Most game shows focus on what contestants have already won.

RISK vs. REWARD also focuses on what they can still become.

Throughout the game, contestants can watch their path to the million-dollar prize remain—or diminish—in real time.

A cautious decision may protect current winnings but reduce the ultimate possibilities.

An aggressive decision may keep the million-dollar dream alive while putting current earnings at risk.

Because the game continuously displays best-case and worst-case outcomes, contestants must weigh security against opportunity at every stage.

And the consequences carry forward. A decision that seems sensible in one round can change the opportunities available in every round that follows.

The result is a unique form of tension: contestants aren't just protecting money.

They're protecting possibilities.

THE PSYCHOLOGY OF CONFIDENCE

Most trivia shows ask one question:

"Do you know the answer?"

RISK vs. REWARD asks a second:

"How sure are you?"

That second question is the heart of the format.

Contestants must continually evaluate not only what they know, but how accurately they understand their own knowledge.

A contestant who risks too much may discover they were overconfident.

A contestant who risks too little may discover they didn't trust themselves enough.

Even correct answers can create regret when a contestant realizes they could have earned more.

And a wrong answer doesn't necessarily mean the decision was foolish. The question is whether the risk was reasonable given what the contestant knew and how confident they were.

Every decision reveals something about a contestant's confidence, judgment, and willingness to accept uncertainty.

The audience gets to make those same judgments along the way.

Would you have taken the risk?

Would you have played it safe?

And would you have trusted yourself?

THE DO-OVER

Each contestant receives one Do-Over, a strategic advantage that can change the course of the game.

During the first six rounds, the contestant may use the Do-Over to replace a question and its result with a fresh question from the remaining category pool.

The replacement gives the contestant another opportunity to make a decision, with a new question and a new Risk/Reward setting.

The Do-Over can erase the consequences of a previous decision, whether the contestant answered correctly or incorrectly, and provides another chance to shape the game.

But timing is everything.

Use it too early, and a contestant may wish they'd saved it. Wait too long, and they risk losing the opportunity to use it during the opening half of the game.

If the Do-Over remains unused through the first six rounds, it becomes a final-question advantage: the contestant gets to choose between two categories for the last question.

It's one more decision that forces contestants to weigh immediate needs against future possibilities.

THE MILLION-DOLLAR DILEMMA

The final question brings every decision into focus.

Consider a contestant who has answered the first eleven questions correctly while maintaining maximum risk.

Current Total: \$533,669.92

A bold final decision could produce:

- \$1,000,000 with a correct answer.
- \$215,443.47 with an incorrect answer.

A more conservative decision could produce:

- \$533,669.92 with a correct answer.
- \$447,017.94 with an incorrect answer.

The contestant sees these possibilities before making the final decision.

The audience sees them too.

There's no hidden wager and no need to guess what a particular risk setting might mean. Both the contestant and viewers can see the consequences before the answer is locked in.

The suspense comes from a simple question:

How much confidence do you have when everything is on the line?

WHY AUDIENCES WILL PLAY ALONG

Every contestant creates a different game.

And in the standard one-hour format, two contestants provide two opportunities to see how differently people approach the same challenge.

One contestant may build steadily, protecting their total and taking calculated risks.

The other may embrace aggressive decisions, pursuing the million-dollar possibility while accepting greater exposure.

Some players become cautious after a setback. Others double down.

Because the two contestants play their own complete games, viewers can compare their strategies without changing the central rules or making the contestants dependent on one another's results.

The audience can play along mentally, evaluate each decision, and compare their own choices with those of the contestants.

Would you risk more?

Would you protect your current total?

Would you keep the million-dollar dream alive?

The debate continues long after the answer is revealed.

The format creates suspense through both knowledge and self-assessment. Viewers aren't simply waiting to see whether someone knows an answer. They're waiting to see whether that person trusts their own judgment—and what that decision will cost or earn.

PRODUCTION

The standard format is designed for a one-hour television presentation featuring two individual contestants, each playing a complete 12-question game.

The two-contestant structure gives the episode two distinct stories, with contrasting personalities, confidence levels, and approaches to risk. Each contestant controls their own game and their own path to the million-dollar prize.

The Risk/Reward Slider serves as the visual centerpiece of the format.

Real-time graphics clearly communicate current totals, potential gains and losses, and future possibilities, allowing viewers to instantly understand the stakes behind every decision.

The slider also gives the show a recognizable visual identity. Every question presents a visible, changing decision that contestants and viewers can follow together.

The format is designed to be visually distinctive, easy to follow, and adaptable for different markets and audiences.

FORMAT VARIATIONS

Standard One-Hour Edition

Two contestants compete individually during the hour, each playing a complete 12-question game.

Their contrasting approaches to knowledge, confidence, and risk provide two distinct journeys toward the million-dollar prize and two opportunities for audience engagement.

Syndicated Half-Hour Edition

The format can also be adapted for a half-hour syndicated presentation featuring one contestant playing a complete game.

This allows the same central mechanics, risk decisions, and million-dollar potential to be presented in a shorter television format.

Couples Edition

Two contestants play as a team, agreeing on every category choice, answer, and Risk/Reward setting.

The format adds a relationship dimension to the central game mechanic. Partners may have different knowledge, different levels of confidence, and very different ideas about how much risk to accept.

One partner may want to protect the current total, while the other believes the opportunity is worth the risk.

The result is a compelling mix of teamwork, negotiation, disagreement, and emotional tension—all built around the same central question:

How sure are you?

CONCLUSION

RISK vs. REWARD combines trivia, strategy, and psychology in a format where contestants control their own destiny.

Two contestants.

Two different strategies.

Twelve questions apiece.

And one million-dollar possibility.

Every answer matters.

Every decision has consequences.

And every player must eventually confront the same question:

How much are you willing to trust yourself when a million dollars is on the line?

Play the interactive demo: <https://eddielawhorn.com/risk-vs-reward/game>

CREATED BY

Eddie Lawhorn

Phone: (256) 975-2238

Email: eddielawhorn@bellsouth.net

Website: <https://eddielawhorn.com>